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In Zusammenarbeit mit

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Research data management and data sharing of qualitative data

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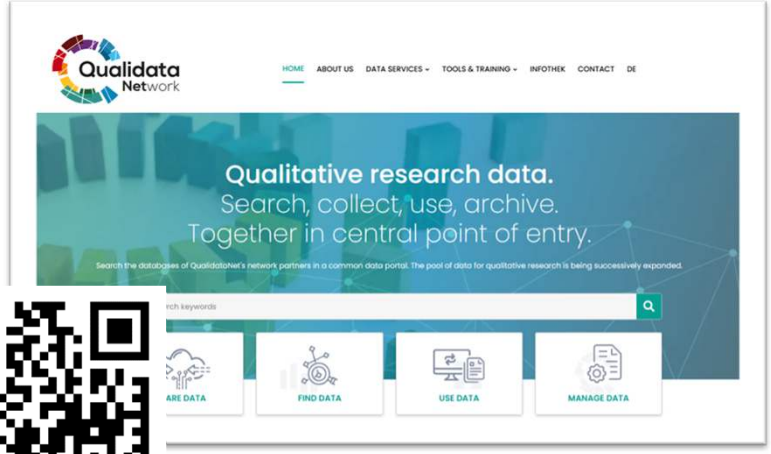
Starting Point for the RDM-Portfolio

- RDM is an integral part of research practice, and offers researchers a wide range of support in handling their research data.
- However, guidelines and templates are often generic, and do not fit with the qualitative research process, which makes them difficult to apply.
- **Research-friendly RDM means integrating the special features of qualitative research.**
- This is the starting point for the QualidataNet-RDM-Portfolio.

QualidataNet – Network for qualitative data

- Network of repositories, which archive research data from qualitative social research and make them available for academic re-use.
- Aims at being a central point of entry for qualiative data and support



https://www.qualidatanet.com/en/

Services:

- Search portal for qualitative data
- Support in searching for suitable archiving partners
- Exchange with the integration of data- or topic-specific expertise, which is the base for joint developments.

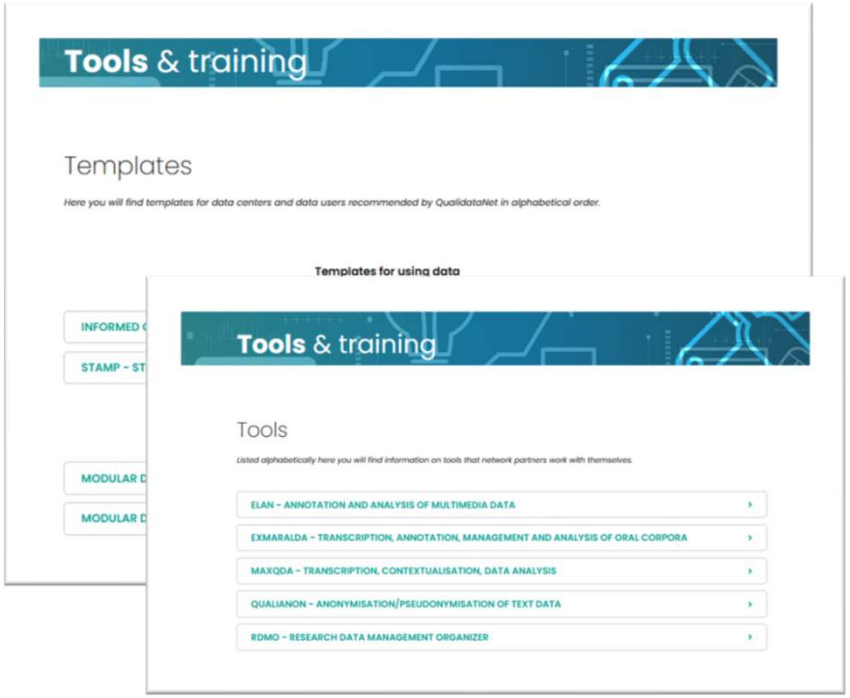
→ one example: *the RDM-Portfolio*

The RDM-Portfolio of QualidataNet

- Website: Overview of best practices, tools and templates that are relevant for the RDM of qualitative data

- Currently: Creation of a guide for RDM and data sharing of qualitative data, summarizing of various RDM-relevant topics

  (pre-registered DOI: /10.26092/elib/3799)



https://www.qualidatanet.com/en/tools-training.html

Central to the RDM of qualitative data is an understanding of how these data are characterized.

- Sensitivity of the data and topics
- Openness of the research process
- Contextuality and (reference) density of the material
- Circularity of the research process
- Diversity of methods and data types
- Individuality and project specificity
- Qualitative researchers are trustingly integrated into the lifeworld of those being researched → special sense of responsibility towards the research participants
- Researcher identify as a research instrument that co-produces knowledge together with the research participants

What does this mean for specific areas of RDM?

Obtaining informed consent (IC) as legal basis for processing personal data

Difficulties when IC is used in qualitative research:

- openness of the research process does not allow the study information to be described in detail
- difficulties in understanding the wording in the IC
- using IC can be perceived as a disturbance of the relationship of trust and have a negative impact on the data collection process
- the IC may not be accepted or understood in communities that culturally legitimise their consent differently (ethnological research)

Obtaining Informed Consent (IC) as legal basis for processing personal data

Solutions can be:

- Use alternatives such as oral IC
- Involve the field in decisions about the use of research data
- Obtain IC for secondary use only after data collection
- Have IC validated by participants at a later stage again

Anonymisation of qualitative data

- Challenge: variety of possible identifiers and high reference density
- Anonymisation reduces the re-use value or make re-use impossible
- Always a study- and dataset-related process → No ‘one size fits all’ (Stam and Kleiner, 2020)

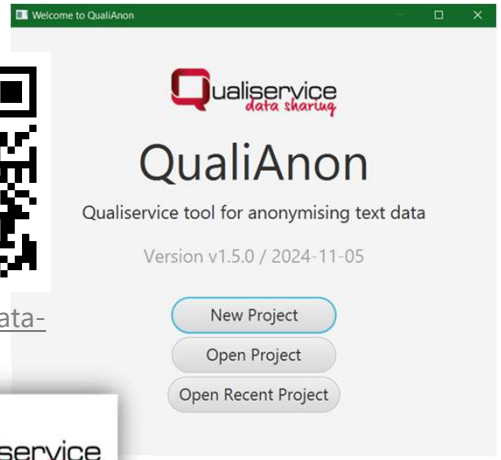
Anonymisation of qualitative data

Possible solutions:

- de facto anonymisation in order to maintain reuse value
- reducing the risk of re-identification through technical and organisational measures (e.g. different security levels for provision from download to onsite use, access regulation: e.g. only qualified scientists with proof of scientific purpose, prohibition of de-identification attempts, individual data provider contracts for defining dataset-specific post-use conditions)
- Use an anonymisation concept that allows social science-relevant information to be obtained and personal information to be protected, e.g. concept of “Flexible Anonymisation” (Mozygemba & Hollstein 2023)

The concept of „Flexible Anonymisation“

- Allows for variously abstracted replacement codes that can be opened and closed depending on the intended use (e.g. onsite or use in teaching)
- It is the basis for the QualiAnon-tool for the anonymisation or pseudonymisation of text data, which is data protection-compliant and developed together with researchers.
- Differentiated replacement schemes and differently abstracted export versions of a text can be created and shared
- Software code was released in May 2025



https://github.com/pangaea-data-publisher/qualianon

https://www.qualiservice.org/en/the-helpdesk/tools.html

German Version: https://doi.org/10.26092/elib/2525
English Version : https://doi.org/10.26092/elib/4029 (*pre-registered*)

Copyright as part of the RDM of qualitative data

- From a certain level of creation (when natural persons have created something new and different from everyday), the contributors (e.g., the research participants) may have copyrights to the data.
- Questions of the level of creation are answered differently for qualitative data than for quantitative data (think of biographical and narrative interviews).
- If contributors have copyrights, they can grant exploitation rights.
- Contractual regulations are used to agree how the data should be handled.

Contextualisation

- The contextual embedding of qualitative data, (incl. institutional, content-related, methodological and situational contexts etc.) is the basis for reconstructing, understanding and comprehending social meaning.
- It is one important condition for re-using qualitative data, especially important to solve the problem of ‘not having been there’ (Heaton, 2004)
- Data centres provide guidance documents and templates (e.g., FSSDA; Heuer et al., 2025; UKDS, Rizzoli et al., 2025).
- Study or methodological reports are published together with the metadata to facilitate the embedding of the dataset in its context of origin
- More sensitive context materials (e.g. codebooks, MAXQDA exports, memos, etc.) are often archived together with the dataset and can be made available for subsequent use depending on the defined access conditions

Research ethics and RDM of qualitative data

- Qualitative research needs an ongoing, repetitive process of reflection.
- Its integration into the various steps of the research process and the RDM is of central importance.
- Research ethics reflection in qualitative research is more complex than in the linear research process because:
  - the openness - challenges can only be anticipated to a limited extent,
  - the sensitivity of the field and the topics,
  - the trust of the field in the researcher as a basis for the willingness to be researched

Examples for reflection on research ethics concerns

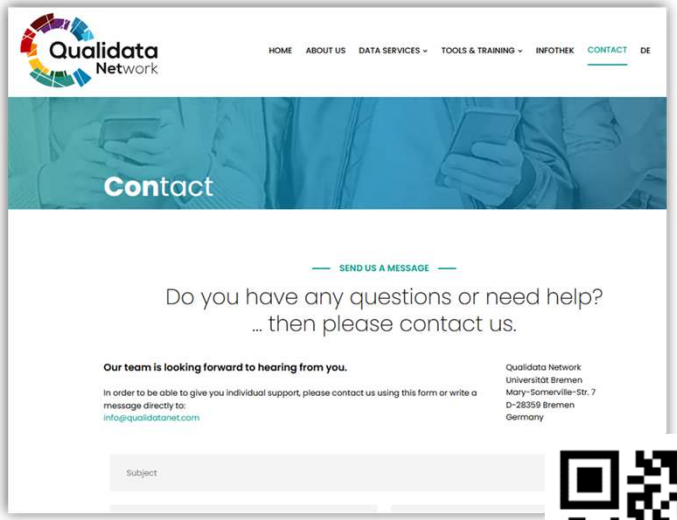
e.g. the role of the researcher in the field, the relationship with research participants, the methodological organisation of the research design, the consideration of subsequent use, the use of technical innovations such as AI/LLM, to what extent does the use of an IC take into account the openness of the research process? Is the IC also an instrument of consent in the analysed community? Does anonymisation possibly take away the voice of parts of the field?

Research ethics and RDM of qualitative data

- Checklists and questionnaires only help to a limited extent (the context in which questions arise for research ethics reflection is missing)
- ‘One-off preliminary review’ (von Unger, 2020) by ethics committees is accepted practice, but does not take into account the openness of the process nor does it support researchers in dealing with challenges in the field where unexpected, difficult situations or ethical dilemmas arise and require quick decisions
- Critical examination of one's own actions and their consequences for the field needs to be repeated in all steps of the data life cycle, including decisions made about actions
- Ethical reflection must be a competence of qualitative researchers → integration into academic training

Conclusion

- Needs its own perspective and flexible tools for RDM of qualitative data that integrate project or data specifics.
- Up to now, the requirements of qualitative research in RDM templates have often been poorly reflected; there is a need to catch up here.
- The QualidataNet RDM-Portfolio is a step towards filling the gap. We are happy to integrate your support templates, guidance etc. into the portfolio.



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